Speak to Travel — EXPRESS: 1-Month Conversation Boost

Teacher's book: the short version of **File 1 (3-Month Program)**. **Students:** Portuguese speakers who **already know English** (they read it, understand a lot, studied grammar) but are **bad at conversation**: they freeze, speak slowly, translate in their heads, can't follow fast speech, or give one-word answers. **Duration:** 4 weeks · 3 sessions per week · 60 minutes = **12 sessions**. **Rule of this program:** the student talks **80%** of the time. There's very little new content and a lot of speaking.

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Uses the same companion files:

- **File 3 (Error Guide)**: error guide (pronunciation, false friends, translated sentences)
- **File 4 (Question Bank)**: role-play question bank
- **File 5 (Student Sheets)**: diagnostic form, "My Story" card, emergency card, certificate

1. Who this is for (and who it's NOT for)

Good fit (use the 6-question diagnostic in section 3):

- Answers basic questions (name, work, family) without much trouble
- Understands slow English well, but gets lost at native speed

- Knows the past tense "on paper" but doesn't use it when speaking
- Says things like: *"Eu entendo tudo, mas na hora de falar trava."* ("I understand everything, but when it's time to speak I freeze.")

Not a good fit, so offer the 12-week program instead:

- Can't answer "What do you do?" or "Tell me about your family"
- Needs most questions repeated in Portuguese

Be honest about this in the first meeting. A weak student in a fast program gets frustrated and quits, and that hurts your reputation.

The promise:

> "In 4 weeks you'll go from 'I understand but I can't speak' to holding a real 10-minute conversation, at normal speed, without freezing. You'll handle any travel situation and an interview with confidence."

The honest limit: one month won't fix every grammar mistake or change the accent. It fixes the **speaking block**, which is usually the student's real problem.

2. What's different from the 12-week program

	12 weeks	
Starting level	Knows a little English	**Knows English, can't speak it**
Main problem attacked	Lack of phrases + fear	**Blocking, slowness, translating, listening speed**
New content	Lots of phrases per week	**Few phrases. Practice using what they already know**
Travel situations	1 per week	**All in one week (W2), at native speed**
Student talking time	70%	**80%**
Correction	Gentle	**More direct. They can take it**
Homework	15 min/day	**20 min/day, all of it speaking**

3. Session 0: diagnostic (before day 1)

30 minutes, free. Use the form in **File 5 (Student Sheets)**, but go harder:

1. **Goals (in Portuguese):** Trip? Interview? Work? Date? What happens when you try to speak?

2. **Speaking (record it):**
    - Tell me about yourself. *(Ask for 2 minutes. Most will stop after 20 seconds, and that tells you a lot.)*
    - What did you do last weekend? Tell me everything.
    - Describe your city to someone who's never been there.
    - What's better: traveling alone or with family? Why?
    - What would you do if your flight was canceled?
    - Tell me about a difficult moment in your life or work.
3. **Listening at native speed:** play 1 minute of a real conversation (a podcast or a TV interview, not a learner video). Ask 3 questions.
4. **Measure:** how many seconds before they start answering? Do they give one-word answers? Do they ask you anything back?

Score with the rubric in section 7. **Keep the recording.** You'll play it in Session 12.

4. The 60-minute Express session

Time	Block	What happens
0–5	**Warm-up**	Real small talk at **normal speed**. No slowing down.
5–15	**Fluency drill**	One of the 5 fluency tools (section 5), usually the 4–3–2.
15–20	**Toolbox**	5–8 phrases or "conversation moves" for today. Quick, no long explanations.
20–45	**Role-plays / discussion**	Long, unscripted, with surprises. Teacher plays natives at natural speed.
45–55	**Error clinic**	Show the 5 mistakes you noted. Student corrects them **out loud**. Then repeat a piece of the role-play correctly.
55–60	**Homework + 1 specific win**	Send it on WhatsApp right after class.

Correction style: during the role-play, don't stop the student. Write the mistakes down. In the error clinic, write each mistake as the student said it and ask *"What's wrong here?"* Students at this level can usually fix it themselves, and fixing it themselves is what makes it stick.

5. The 5 fluency tools

These are the core of the Express program. Use one or two in every session.

Tool 1 — 4-3-2

The student talks about one topic for **4 minutes**. Then the **same topic for 3 minutes**, then again for **2 minutes**. Each round they say the same content faster and more smoothly. It's a well-known fluency exercise, and the student can feel the improvement in a single session.

Tool 2 — Buy time (fillers)

Brazilians go silent when they're thinking, and in English a long silence feels uncomfortable. Teach natural "thinking sounds":

- *Well… / Let me think… / That's a good question… / How can I put this… / I mean… / You know… / Actually…*
- Ban "é…" and "tipo…" in class. The student pays 1 point every time they use one.

Tool 3 — Paraphrase (when the word is missing)

Don't stop the conversation because you don't know one word. Go around it:

- *It's a kind of… / It's something you use to… / It's like a… but… / I don't know the word, but it's the thing that…*
- **Game, "Forbidden Word":** describe an object (a word on a card) without saying it. The teacher guesses.

Tool 4 — Shadowing

Play 1 minute of real native speech. The student repeats **right behind the speaker**, about half a second later, copying the speed, the melody and the way words connect. This trains both listening and speaking at the same time.

Tool 5 — Follow-up questions (ask back)

Students who know English often answer well and then stop. Every answer should end with a question back:

- *And you? / What about you? / Have you ever…? / How was it? / Why did you…? / What was the best part?*
- **Rule in class:** any answer without a question back is "incomplete" (except in immigration interviews, where you answer short and don't ask back).

6. The 4 weeks, session by session

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WEEK 1 — UNBLOCK         "I start speaking right away and I don't stop"
WEEK 2 — TRAVEL AT REAL SPEED   "I handle every travel situation, even with surprises"
WEEK 3 — KEEP IT ALIVE   "I can have a real back-and-forth conversation"
WEEK 4 — GO DEEPER + FINAL  "I give opinions, tell stories, pass an interview"
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WEEK 1 — UNBLOCK

Session 1 — Fluency over perfection

- **Talk with the student (in Portuguese, 3 min):** in conversation, being understood matters more than being correct. Mistakes are allowed. Silence is the real problem.
- **Fluency drill:** 4–3–2 on *"Tell me about yourself."*
- **Toolbox:** fillers (Tool 2) + the survival phrases: *Sorry, could you repeat that? / What do you mean by…? / Could you say that in a different way?*
- **Role-play:** "Speed questions". The teacher fires 20 personal questions and the student must start answering in **under 3 seconds**.
- **Homework:** record a 2-minute voice message: "Tell me about yourself." Start the "My Story" card.

Session 2 — When you don't know the word

- **Fluency drill:** 4–3–2 on *"Describe your city / your house."*
- **Toolbox:** paraphrasing (Tool 3).
- **Activities:** Forbidden Word game (10 cards). Then "Describe the picture": the student describes a busy photo in detail for 3 minutes.
- **Error clinic:** focus on the classic "translated" sentences from **File 3 (Error Guide)** that this student makes.
- **Homework:** "Talk to yourself" for 5 minutes a day: describe what you're doing in English while cooking or driving.

Session 3 — Listening at native speed

- **Fluency drill:** shadowing (Tool 4) with a 1-minute dialogue.
- **Toolbox: connected speech**, meaning how natives really say it: *gonna, wanna, gotta, "whaddaya", "didja", "lemme", "kinda"*, and words that run together (*"turn_it_off", "pick_it_up"*).
- **Activity:** "Real-speed dictation". The teacher says 10 fast sentences and the student writes them, then says them at the same speed.
- **Free talk (15 min):** what are your goals for this month? What was hardest this week?
- **Self-check** (fichas, sheet 3). Record a short audio sample for comparison.

WEEK 2 — TRAVEL AT REAL SPEED

> The student "knows" travel English already. This week is about doing it **fast, with surprises**, and without the phrase sheet. Use **File 4 (Question Bank)**.

Session 4 — Airport + immigration

- **Warm-up:** quick review of the polite requests *Could I… / I'd like… / Would it be possible…* (instead of *"I want…"*).
- **Role-plays:** check-in → security (fast commands) → **immigration** with the 3 officer types: friendly, neutral-fast and serious (bank section 1).
- **Immigration rules (say them in Portuguese):** short, true, direct answers. Answer only what was asked. Don't fill silences.
- **Surprise:** flight canceled → rebooking at the counter.
- **Homework:** prepare **your own true answers** to the 10 most common immigration questions. Record them as audio.

Session 5 — Hotel + restaurant + shopping

- **Fluency drill:** shadowing a real fast barista / waiter dialogue.
- **Toolbox:** polite complaints: *I'm sorry to bother you, but… / I think there's a mistake… / Would it be possible to…?*
- **Role-plays (with problem cards):** hotel check-in → wrong room → restaurant with a fast waiter → wrong dish → split the check and tip → return an item at a store.
- **Culture:** in the US, a 15–20% tip is expected, and sales tax is added when you pay.
- **Homework:** watch a real travel vlog in English (10 min, English subtitles) and write 5 phrases you'd use.

Session 6 — Problems & emergencies + "Full Trip"

- **Role-plays:** doctor (symptoms, medication, allergies), pharmacy, stolen bag / police report, lost luggage.
- **Big role-play (20 min): "Full Trip Simulation"**. Airport → immigration → Uber → hotel → restaurant → feeling sick → pharmacy. The teacher changes character every 3–4 minutes. No preparation and no phrase sheet.
- **Homework:** make the Emergency Card (fichas, sheet 4). **Checkpoint:** score the Full Trip with the rubric.

WEEK 3 — KEEP THE CONVERSATION ALIVE

Session 7 — Small talk that doesn't die

- **Fluency drill:** 4–3–2 on *"Your last trip."*

- **Toolbox:** follow-up questions (Tool 5) + reactions: *Oh really? / No way! / That's amazing! / Me too / Me neither / That makes sense.*
- **Small talk in 3 parts:** start (*Is this your first time here? / Beautiful day, isn't it?*), keep it going (follow-ups), finish (*It was great talking to you. Enjoy your trip!*).
- **Game, "Keep it alive":** the teacher gives short, boring answers. The student must keep the conversation going for 5 minutes.
- **Homework:** prepare 30-second answers to *"What's Brazil like? Is it safe? What should I eat there?"* Foreigners always ask these.

Session 8 — Telling stories

- **Fluency drill:** shadowing a short story from a podcast.
- **Toolbox:** story connectors: *So… / Then… / Suddenly… / Anyway… / The funny thing is… / Long story short…* Also the past-tense verbs they know but avoid: *went, got, took, saw, told, felt, bought, thought.*
- **Activity, "Photo stories":** the student brings 5 real photos from their phone and tells the story behind each one. The teacher interrupts with questions (*Wait, who was that? Then what happened?*).
- **Error clinic focus:** using the present when they mean the past (*"yesterday I go"*), and the final **-ED** pronunciation.
- **Homework:** record "The best (or worst) trip of my life" in 3 minutes.

Session 9 — Real conversation practice

- **This session is almost all free conversation (40 min)** on topics the student picks from a list: work, family, food, travel, movies or series, sports, city life vs. country life, technology, health, dreams.
- **The teacher acts like a real conversation partner:** shares their own opinions, interrupts naturally, changes the subject, makes jokes. Not "teacher mode".
- **Last 15 min:** error clinic + self-check.
- **Optional real-world mission:** before Session 12, the student talks with a real English speaker. That could be a friend of yours on a video call, a language-exchange app, or a tourist.

WEEK 4 — GO DEEPER + FINAL

Session 10 — Opinions & discussion

- **Fluency drill:** 4-3-2 on *"Something you would change in your city."*
- **Toolbox:** *I think… / In my opinion… / I see your point, but… / I'm not so sure about that / It depends / On the other hand… / I'd rather…*
- **Mini-debates (the teacher takes the opposite side on purpose):** beach vs. mountains · cruise vs. road trip · big city vs. small town · is social media good or bad? · is it better to travel young or older?
- **Hypothetical:** *If I could live anywhere, I'd… / What would you do if…?*
- **Homework:** prepare a 2-minute talk: "My dream trip" or "A change I'd like to make in my life."

Session 11 — Interview day

- **Pick the interview the student actually needs:**
  - **Immigration/border:** the "serious officer" version, longer, with lots of follow-ups.
  - **Job interview in English:** *Tell me about yourself / Strengths and weaknesses / A difficult problem you solved (STAR: Situation, Task, Action, Result) / Do you have any questions for us?* (bank section 9)
  - **Social interview:** meeting a friend's family, a dinner party.
- **Run it twice.** Round 1, then feedback, then Round 2. Compare the two.
- **Homework:** do your preparation and get a good night's sleep. Tomorrow is the final.

Session 12 — Final assessment & graduation

1. **Final recorded conversation (25 min):** "Tell me about yourself" (2 min) → immigration interview (5 min) → a story (3 min) → opinion debate (5 min) → free conversation (10 min).
2. **Score with the rubric** and compare with the diagnostic.
3. **Play the diagnostic recording, then today's.**
4. **Certificate** (fichas, sheet 5. Change it to "Express: 12 sessions").
5. **"Keep going on your own" plan:** shadow 10 min a day, watch one series with English subtitles, have one conversation a week, re-read the My Story card.
6. **Offer the next step:** a monthly maintenance plan (for example, 1–2 classes a week) or more Express months with new topics. Ask for a testimonial and referrals.

7. Assessment

Use the same **6-area rubric (score 1–5, total /30)** from File 1, section 7: Fluency · Comprehension · Vocabulary · Accuracy · Pronunciation · Interaction.

Check at: Session 0 (diagnostic) → Session 6 (Full Trip checkpoint) → Session 12 (final).

Also measure these numbers. Students love seeing them improve:

Measure	Session 0	Session 12
"Tell me about yourself" before they stop (seconds)		
Seconds before they start answering		
Times they switched to Portuguese in 10 min		
Follow-up questions they asked in 5 min of small talk		

Typical journey for this level: about 14–17 at the diagnostic → about 19–23 at the final.

8. Daily homework (20 min)

All homework is **speaking**. Send it on WhatsApp after each class.

Every day	Task
5 min	**Shadowing** a 1–minute real audio clip (podcast, series, vlog)
5 min	**Talk to yourself** in English: describe your day or what you're doing
10 min	**Voice message to the teacher** on the topic of the week. The teacher replies with a short audio and 2–3 corrections.

The voice messages matter most. Hearing their own voice improve week after week is what keeps students motivated.

9. Selling the Express version

- **Who buys it:** people with a trip or interview coming soon, people who "studied English for years but can't speak", former students of English courses, professionals.
- **Package:** 12 sessions in 1 month, paid upfront. Charge a bit more per hour than the 12–week program (it's more intensive and needs more preparation), or the same per hour with no discount. **Check what other teachers in your area charge first.**
- **After the month:** offer a **monthly maintenance plan** (1–2 classes a week). That's where the steady income is.
- **Upgrade path:** someone who fails the Session 0 diagnostic → offer the 12–week program instead.
- **Pitch line:** *"Você já sabe inglês. Em um mês, você vai conseguir FALAR inglês."* ("You already know English. In one month, you'll be able to SPEAK English.")